not a relationship between a central government and an outlying province'.[73]

With the end of the limited influence the Chinese had enjoyed in Tibet, the Tibetans were now able to build a more truly independent nation. The border with British India was clear, as the Tibetan delegate at Shimla, Lönchen Shatra, had stated in a message to Henry McMahon,

> As it was feared that there might be friction in future unless the boundary between India and Tibet is clearly defined, I submitted the map, which you sent me in February last, to Lhasa for orders. I have now received orders from Lhasa, and I accordingly agree to the boundary as marked in red in the two copies of the maps signed by you subject to conditions, mentioned in your letter dated 24th March, sent to me through Mr. Bell. I have signed and sealed the two copies of the maps. I have kept one copy here and return herewith the other.[74]

The 'boundary marked in red', of course, was the McMahon Line and 'Mr. Bell' was Charles Bell.

Thus, even the Tibetans would find it preposterous to claim that the McMahon Line was 'secret', and it is equally misleading to say that documents relating to it were 'discovered' by Caroe in the 1930s. Not much may have been done to establish any actual administration in the area between the plains of Assam and the McMahon Line, but in 1928, Captain Nevill, a political officer in the Balipara Frontier Tract, north of the Inner Line, informed the Indian government that in the event of a Chinese attempt to gain control over Tibet, Tawang would provide a 'secret and easy entrance into India'.[75]

Tawang was one of those areas where it was difficult to determine whether it was north or south of the McMahon Line. Henry McMahon's red line on the map puts the border roughly at Sela Pass, 78 kilometres south of Tawang. But according to the principle on which the McMahon Line was based—that it should be drawn along the highest peaks in the Himalayas and linked by watersheds—the border would be at Bumla Pass, northeast of Tawang. In his final memorandum at the Shimla Conference, McMahon discovered this, and briefly discussed the inclusion of Tawang in Indian territory, 'This secures to us a natural watershed frontier, access to the shortest trade route into Tibet, and control of the monastery of Tawang, which has blocked the trade by this route in the past by undue exaction and oppression.'[76]